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Date: 28 November 2002

Exhibit 13.14: Sample Cover Letter and Resumé 2

As discussed in this chapter, business letters project your organization's image. Hence, they not only need to have good appearance but also need to be clear, concise, correct, complete, and courteous. The principles discussed in this chapter will enable you to achieve these five C's of letter writing. These principles are applicable to all business letters, irrespective of their types.

MEMOS

There are three important channels through which information flows within the various sections of an organization. Employees can communicate face-to-face, over telephone or through an inter-office memorandum, which, in short, is called a memo. Memos (or memoranda) are written by everyone from junior executives and engineers to Chief Executive Officers. When you think of a memo, what do you think of? It could be a small piece of paper with a letterhead that says something like:

'From the desk of ...' or 'Don't forget ...' or 'Reminders ...'

The message itself may be very simple—something like:

'Buy more paper clips' or 'Meet with President at 2:30' or 'We are running out of storage space'.

While these memos are informative or persuasive, and may serve their simple purposes, more complex memos are often needed in an office setting. But do not let that worry you. Even though business memos may be more formal and complicated, the intention in writing one is still the same.

Basically, memos are brief written communications circulated within an organization. They not only facilitate communication about various operations but also play an important role in arriving at some quick decisions. For example, the production manager of a fabrics company can decide which type of fabric

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needs to be produced more on the basis of information provided in a memo from the marketing manager.

Memos solve problems either by informing the reader about new information, like policy changes, price increases, etc. or by persuading the reader to take an action, such as attend a meeting, use less paper, or change a current production procedure. Inter-office memos enable the flow of information in all the three types of organizational communication, namely vertical, horizontal, and diagonal. The President of an organization can send a memo to the Vice President (vertical), a Vice President of one division can send a memo to the Vice President of another division (horizontal), or the President can send a memo to an employee directly without going through the hierarchical set-up inside the organization (diagonal). In short, they help in bridging the communication gap among the various sections of any organization and also serve as permanent records of information.

Regardless of the specific goal, memos are most effective when they connect the purpose of the writer with the interests and needs of the reader.

Classification and Purpose

No other kind of written communication reaches so many people at so many levels as does a memo in an organization. The larger the organization you work for and the more levels of authority it has, the more inefficient phone calls and face-to-face discussion become. A memo is a good way to reach many people at once. Of course e-mail is nowadays used in most organizations to convey information in whatever written form you may choose—memo, circular, or notice.

A memo is important not only because of its frequency of use and the wide range of subject matter presented in memo form, but also because memos represent a component of your interpersonal communication skills within your work environment. By keeping your purpose and reader in mind and by giving careful consideration to organization, completeness, and tone, you will be able to write effective memos that will contribute to your efficient functioning within the organization.

Depending on their purpose, memos can be classified into three major categories:

- Documentary
- Congratulatory
- Disciplinary

Documentary Memos

As the name suggests, these memos are mainly used for conveying information. You may need to write a memo to your subordinate to remind, to announce, to give instructions, to explain a policy or procedure, to your peer or superior to make a request or routine recommendation, or to confirm an agreement. For

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instance, a memo explaining the new method of maintaining the medical records of employees in an organization; requesting the head of another division to provide additional manpower for shifting some huge machines; providing some suggestions for improving the existing billing system—all fall under this category. Short reports also can be submitted in the form of documentary memos. Such reports are called memo reports. These are discussed in Chapter 14 under the heading Types of Reports.

Congratulatory Memos

Memos are also used to give credit to employees of an organization for the outstanding work they have accomplished. It is appropriate for the Vice-Chancellor of a university to send a memo to the faculty members congratulating their outstanding contribution to the field of research. Similarly the employees can also send their compliments in the form of a memo to their officers, for the awards or achievements which the latter have earned.

Disciplinary Memos

When employees violate the rules or breach the code of conduct in an organization, they will be served either with a severe warning or any other punishment as decided by the management. The memo conveying this action is known as disciplinary memo. For instance, a memo may be issued to an officer who has accepted a bribe from one of the customers.

Uses of Memos:

- to request for action or information. This helps you to have a written record of what you have asked. As compared to an oral request, this type of written request is more difficult for your audience to forget or ignore.
- to explain to the reader something that is not understood. Your purpose in this case is to make something clear for your reader.
- to announce or to give formal notice to readers, publicly informing them about new procedures, new products, or anything that you want to be publicly known.
- to confirm the details of a meeting, conversation, or telephone call. This would enable you to have a written record of decisions that were made or promises that were given.
- to suggest solutions to business problems, to offer your services or those of your department, or to bring up new ideas or ways of doing things.
- to report the details of a project at regular intervals as a way of helping the organization keep track of progress and problems.

Structure and Layout

Standard memos are divided into five main segments to organize information and to help achieve the writer's purpose. However, depending on the requirements, you may need to add two more segments, one for attachments and the other for distribution of copies.

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- Heading Segment
- Opening Segment
- Discussion Segment(s)
- Closing Segment
- Signature Segment
- Necessary Attachments Segment (optional)
- Distribution Segment (Optional)

Organizations generally provide printed memo forms to their various divisions which contain all the segments mentioned above. You can look at the sample template given in Exhibit 13.5.

National Steel Industries Ltd
12, Gandhi Marg, New Delhi-110002

Interoffice Memorandum

DATE:

TO:

FROM:

SUBJECT:

(opening)

(Discussion)

(Discussion)

(Closing)

Signature

Attachments:

Distribution:

Exhibit 13.15: Sample Memo Template

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Heading

The heading segment follows this general format:

- Name of the organization and address (Printed Letterhead)
- Date: (Complete and current date)
- To: (Designation of the recipient)
- From: (Designation of the sender)
- Subject: (What the memo is about, highlighted in some way)

Since memos are used for communication within the organization, it is enough if the designations of the sender and the recipient are mentioned against *To* and *From* in the layout.

Almost every recipient reads the subject line which gives a clear idea of the topic discussed in the memo. The subject line, typed in capitals, is where you begin talking to your reader(s). One-word subject lines do not communicate effectively, as in the following flawed subject line.

Subject: SUPERVISORS

Such a subject line gives you a vague idea about the contents of the memo, but lacks focus. A better subject line for this would be:

Subject: SALARY INCREASE FOR SUPERVISORS

A few more samples of subject lines are given below:

- *PERMISSION TO CHANGE PROCEDURE*
- *REQUEST FOR FOUR MACHINES*
- *DETAILS OF TRAINING PROGRAMME*
- *TERMINATION OF SERVICES*
- *ARRANGEMENTS FOR THE CONFERENCE*

You may find that the topic and the main focus are connected by a preposition in all these examples. Such a combination works well in all subject lines and clarifies the actual subject matter of the memo to your reader.

Opening

The purpose of a memo is usually found in the opening paragraphs and is presented in three parts: the context and problem, the specific assignment or task, and the purpose of the memo.

1. The context is the event, circumstance, or background of the problem you are solving or the topic you are handling in your memo. You may use a paragraph to establish the background and state the problem or simply the opening of a sentence, such as, 'In our effort to reduce the absenteeism in our Division ....' Include only what your reader needs, but be sure it is clear.
2. In the task statement you should describe what you are doing to help solve the problem. If the action was requested, your task may be indicated by a sentence opening like, 'You asked that I look at ....' If you want to explain your intentions,

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you might say, 'To determine the best method of controlling the percentage of absenteeism, I took recourse to three methods ....'

3. Finally, the purpose statement of a memo gives you reason for writing it and forecasts what is in the rest of the memo. Make sure that this statement is forthright and explains to the reader exactly what is in store. For example, you might say: 'This memo presents a description of the current situation, some proposed alternatives, and my recommendations.' If you plan to use headings for your memo segments, you can refer to your major headings in this forecast statement to provide a better guide for your reader.

- Include only as much information as is needed by the decision makers in the context, but be convincing that a real problem exists. Do not ramble on with insignificant details.
- If you have trouble putting the task into words, consider whether you are clear in your mind about the situation. You may need to do more planning before you are ready to write your memo.
- Make sure your purpose statement forecast divides your subject into the most important topics that the decision maker needs.

To summarize, your memo should start with one or two clear sentences to tell your reader the need and purpose of your communication. For instance, the introductory paragraph of a memo from the Manager of the Training Division of a company to the Vice President of that company may contain the following few lines:

As directed by you in your memo dated 21st July 2003, I analysed the possibilities of offering a three-week training programme to our supervisors. I am submitting my views on organizing this programme in the lines that follow:

Generally, when you write a memo requesting somebody to provide something the memo may be very short and hence need not contain an introductory paragraph separately. In this case, the introduction and discussion would be combined as shown below:

As directed by our President, we are trying to complete the work by tonight. To accelerate the pace of work, I request you to spare two computers on loan basis for tonight only.

Discussion

The discussion segments are the parts where you develop the arguments that support your ideas. For example, if you write a memo to your superior who has asked you to analyse the feasibility of offering some new services to employees, you can explain the details of your analysis in this section. If you are directing your subordinate to conduct a survey on the effectiveness of the new machines introduced in your division, you can give the specific details regarding the aspects you want to be examined. Since very few readers read every line of the memos they receive, keep your communication brief.

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Hints on the Discussion Segment

1. Begin with the information that is most important. This means that you will start with key findings or recommendations.
2. Here you want to think of an inverted pyramid. Start with your most general information and move to your specific or supporting facts. (Be sure to use the same format when including details: strongest→weakest.)
3. Try to make your text more reader-friendly by applying boldface type, headings, columns, and graphics.
4. For easy reading, put important points or details into lists rather than paragraphs when possible.
5. Be careful to make lists parallel in grammatical form.

The two examples given below will show you how the discussion segment(s) of a memo appear:

Example 1

I personally went to the reprography section of our institute and found out that the photo copier is not effective because of the poor quality of stationery used. The paper used is very thin and hence the impressions of one side fall on the other.

Example 2

Our committee examined the case and the details are given below:

1. Adequate quotations were not received for the purchase of the two machines. We found out that there are five dealers for the sale of these machines in our locality.
2. The machines were not properly checked as soon as they were received. They were sent to the production division directly.
3. The Purchase Manager does not have adequate explanations for this casual action.

Closing

Now you're almost done. After the reader has absorbed all of your information, you want to close with a courteous ending that states what action you want your reader to take. Always consider how the reader will benefit from the desired actions and how you can make those actions easier. For example, you might say, 'I will be glad to discuss this recommendation with you during our Tuesday trip to Delhi and follow through on any decisions you make'.

Your memo can end with some complimentary remarks or directive statements. While a complimentary close motivates your readers and makes them feel happy, a directive close tells them what exactly you want them to do next or what your plans are. Here are examples of these two types of closing statements.

Complimentary Close

- If our results continue to improve at this rate, we will attract more students during the coming years. Congratulations!
- Please accept my compliments to you for introducing this new computing system in your Division.
- There is no doubt that your conscientious efforts would help us accomplish our task without any difficulty. Keep it up!

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Directive Close

- I would like to resolve the issue only after hearing from you. Hence kindly inform me before 25th August 2003.
- To complete your analysis in time, our Finance Manager would provide the necessary data tomorrow, the 23rd August 2003. Please bring along with you the registration details of the newly acquired land.

Necessary Attachments

Make sure you document your findings or provide detailed information whenever necessary. You can do this by attaching lists, graphs, tables, etc. at the end of your memo. Be sure to refer to your attachments in your memo and add a notation about what is attached below your closing, like this:

- Attached: Director's approval letter
- Attached: Several Complaints about Product, January–June 2001
- Attached: List of absentees on 17th July 2003

Distribution

This last segment is used to mention the designations of those people to whom you would like to send a copy or some copies of your memo. As already said, this segment is not mandatory in a memo. The short form of complimentary copy, that is, *Cc:*, can also be used instead of the word *distribution:*

Distribution
Assistant Manager, Operations
Supervisor, Manufacturing

Distribution
All Associate Professors

Cc: Personnel Manager with a request to circulate among the employees
Budget Officer
Assistant Manager, Finance

Style

As regards the style of memos, your organization and your relationship with your readers suggest the degree of formality or informality you should adopt in your memos. In some companies, a formal style is expected; in others, a handwritten note or informality in style is the rule. Some bosses—those who believe in the importance of upholding status distinctions—want your memos to sound formal and distant in a way that is appropriate to your subordinate position. Others—those who have an open and participative approach to managing—want you to use the first person, contractions, and even sentence fragments to create an informal and conversational style. While writing a memo, therefore, you may

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choose the style that suits you but keep in mind that a friendly tone and courtesy are always required to suggest your association with the reader.

Generally, your tone will be neutral or positive, but you may occasionally have to issue complaints or reprimands in memo form. Use caution in negative situations, and be aware of the effect of your correspondence. If you are spiteful, blunt, condescending, or too coldly formal, you will end up alienating people. Ostentatious language, excessively technical jargon, or complicated syntax will make you sound pompous. You should aim to sound cordial, straightforward, and lucid. Develop a relaxed and conversational style without being too chatty. If you project an image of consideration, you stand a much greater chance of being viewed as knowledgeable and competent in carrying out your professional responsibilites.

Make sure to keep your memos as short and to-the-point as possible. Whether the news is good, bad, or neutral, state your point in the opening segment. If the memo is lengthy, you should also provide an indication of its organization in the opening segment.

Exhibits 13.6–13.20 illustrate some memos.

ELITE CYCLES LIMITED
JAIPUR

Interoffice Memorandum

Date: 10 May 2003

To: Production Manager
From: Personnel Manager
Subject: CHANGE IN WORKING HOURS

Please refer to your memo pd/21 dated 6th May 2003 requesting for a change in working hours of your division because of the extremely hot weather conditions.

As desired by you, the Vice President, Personnel, has agreed to change the working hours. The new timings will be 7.00 a.m. to 1.00 p.m. (Monday through Saturday) with effect from 17th May 2003 to 16th July 2003.

Kindly inform all the employees working under you.

K.S. Shah

Exhibit 13.16: SAMPLE MEMO 1

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FEATHERTOUCH FOAM INDUSTRIES LTD
12, GANDHI MARG, AHMEDABAD

Date: 20 August 2003

To: Public Relations Manager

From: Labour Welfare Officer

Subject: STAFF WELFARE FUND

You may recall that when I talked to you over phone yesterday, you agreed to my suggestions to create a Staff Welfare Fund to extend financial assistance to our employees and their families in times of prolonged illness or premature death.

I have discussed the matter with the Finance Manager. Though in principle he endorsed the idea, he has suggested that the detailed guidelines should be prepared for the operation of this fund. Hence I suggest that we may constitute a three member committee consisting of the following officers to work out the details:

Human Resource Manager (Convener)
Labour Welfare officer
Budget Officer

I am awaiting your approval to proceed further.

P.K. Singh

Exhibit 13.17: SAMPLE MEMO 2

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National Institute of Technology
Worli, Mumbai

Interoffice Memorandum

Date: 25 August 2003

To : Dean, Educational Hardware Division

From: Manager, Reprography Unit

Subject: PURCHASE OF THREE PHOTOCOPIERS

With the addition of four new departments and consequent increase in the number of both faculty and students, the volume of work in the reprography unit has considerably gone up.

The two Parrot photocopiers that we have at present are no longer adequate to meet the demands. These machines were bought seven years ago and have become obsolete. Moreover, they break down frequently and need major repairs. This year alone we have spent Rs 25000/- to keep them in working condition.

Our estimate shows that we now require at least three more photocopiers to cope with the increasing demand. We have also studied the features and the cost of various brands of photocopiers currently available in the market.

We recommend the purchase of three Cuckoo photocopiers manufactured by Jungle Ltd, Mumbai. The price list is enclosed.

I request your approval for the purchase of these three photocopiers.

Saif Ali

Exhibit 13.18: SAMPLE MEMO 3

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RK Home Furnishers Limited
Hyder Chowk
Hyderabad

Date: 31 July 2003

To : Personnel Manager

From: Vice President, Marketing

Subject: DETAILS FOR SALES MEETING

As we discussed in my office today, please get the necessary details pertaining to the expenses for holding our annual sales meeting at the Ashoka Hotel, Mumbai. As we are planning to begin the meeting on the morning of Monday, 4th September, we should reach the venue on 3rd September. We will leave after a short morning session on 6th September.

Send me the following information:

- Travel costs for 25 participants, including air travel to Mumbai and travel between the airport and our lodge. I have enclosed the list containing the names and addresses of all the participants.
- Room and board costs for the three day period including cost with and without dinner. As you know, we may allow participants to have their dinner outside.
- Costs for recreational facilities at the hotel.
- Costs for meeting room spacious enough to accommodate 25 participants, and necessary equipment such as projectors, lecterns, computers, etc.

I would like to have the information **by 10th August**. You can contact me at **x841** or raju@hotmail.com in case you need any further information.

Rajesh

Attached: One list

Exhibit 13.19: SAMPLE MEMO 4

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E-MAILS

The phenomenally rapid growth of the Internet and its widespread use in business has changed the way in which organizations communicate. Chances are good that the organization you work for will have Internet access, and you may have a personal e-mail address. Many companies are promoting the use of e-mail for most—if not all—in-house correspondence, and a great deal of communicating with outside organizations also relies on e-mail.

E-mail offers some tremendous advantages. It is fast—a message can be sent to as many people as necessary instantaneously. It is inexpensive. The cost of printing out and making copies of memos is eliminated. It is convenient. People can check their e-mail without leaving their desks. No time is lost in waiting for messages to reach them.

But e-mail is a completely different world in terms of writing. For one thing, it is very informal. E-mail does not require strict attention to grammatical rules. Page design does not exist. Even organization is kind of up for grabs.

The reason behind these differences is that, until a couple of years ago, a line of e-mail could not be changed once it was typed. Revision was impossible, so people learned to accept and even expect a certain level of error. Now, of course, e-mail can be revised. But people have grown so fond of the informality of e-mail that it has become a standard feature of the genre.

E-mail also has its own vocabulary of acronyms. Some of the most common ones are listed in this chapter. E-mail combines most of the best—and a few of the worst—characteristics of the more well-known methods of communicating, including postal mail, telephone, and fax. You can do several things with e-mail that are difficult or impossible with any other form of communication. While e-mail is an efficient way to communicate, it is also subject to limitations. In particular, you must recognize when e-mail is appropriate and when it is not. For example, when writing about emotionally charged subjects (or when the person you are writing to may become angry, defensive, or otherwise upset about a subject), or when you are angry, a face-to-face conversation is generally more appropriate than e-mail. Similarly, discussing confidential matters or very complex issues is often better done in other ways than through e-mail.

Advantages and Limitations of E-mail

Advantages

- You can communicate quickly with anyone on the Internet. E-mail usually reaches its destination in a span of minutes or seconds.
- It is easy to send your message to more than one person. You just type in several e-mail addresses. You can also keep mailing lists on your computer, which allows quick distribution to many people.

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can retrieve long-deleted messages. An ill-conceived e-mail may come back to haunt you in the future.

Similarly, poor spelling and grammar in e-mail messages could lead some readers to question your competence. Although problems with spelling and grammar are generally ignored in such forums as the various *Internet Newsgroups* (indeed, commenting on these sorts of issues is generally considered bad Internet manners), they are generally frowned on in school and industry. Sending an e-mail memo filled with spelling errors to an instructor, client, or supervisor is ill-advised. Always take the time to ask yourself who will be reading your message and what effect its tone, style, grammar, and spelling may have.

E-mail Etiquettes

There are many etiquette guides and many different etiquette rules. Some rules will differ according to the nature of your business and the corporate culture. Here we list what we consider as the 24 most important e-mail etiquette rules that apply to nearly all formal communication situations.

1. Answer swiftly.

People send an e-mail because they wish to receive a quick response. If they did not want a quick response they would send a letter or a fax. Therefore, each e-mail should be replied to within at least 24 hours, and preferably within the same working day. If the e-mail is complicated, just send an e-mail back saying that you have received it and that you will get back to them. This will put the reader's mind at rest and usually they will then be very patient!

2. Do not overuse Reply to All.

Use Reply to All only if you really need your message to be seen by each person who received the original message.

3. Use templates for frequently used responses.

If you often tend to receive the same queries, such as directions to your office or how to subscribe to your newsletter, save your replies as response templates and paste these into your message when you need them. You can save your templates in a Word document, or use pre-formatted e-mails. Even better is a tool such as *ReplyMate for Outlook* (allows you to use 10 templates for free).

4. Use proper structure and layout.

Since reading from a screen is more difficult than reading from paper, the structure and layout is very important for e-mail messages. Use short paragraphs and blank lines between each paragraph. When making points, number them or mark each point as separate to keep the overview.

5. Identify yourself and the topic.

Where possible, identify yourself on the *From:* line using your full name rather than just your e-mail address. For example, use "Amit Kumar Saxena" aks@vu.edu.in rather than just aks@vu.edu.in. Recipients are more likely to

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respond to you if they can easily identify who you are. In addition, knowing whom a message is from helps the recipient put the message in context.

At the end of your messages, include an alternative way to be contacted (i.e. phone number, FAX, postal address) along with your name. You can provide this information in a signature field that can be turned off for more personal e-mails. Providing contact information is especially important if you are asking for an answer that is likely to be quite complex. Often less time is required to explain something complex over the phone or in person than to type out the message.

The information on your subject line should be meaningful to the recipient as well as yourself. For instance, when you send an e-mail to a company requesting information about a product, it is better to mention the actual name of the product, e.g., 'Product A information', than to say just 'Product information' or the company's name in the subject.

6. Answer all questions, and pre-empt further questions.

An e-mail reply must answer all questions, and pre-empt further questions. If you do not answer all the questions in the original e-mail, you will receive further e-mails regarding the unanswered questions, which will not only waste your time and your reader's time but also cause considerable frustration. Moreover, if you are able to pre-empt relevant questions, your reader will be grateful and impressed with your efficiency and thoughtfulness. Imagine for instance that an off campus student sends you (assume that you are a professor of Electronics Engineering) an e-mail asking some doubts on a lesson. Instead of just explaining the answer to the student's problem, if you mention some other sources which he/she can refer to for further understanding, the student will definitely appreciate this extra information.

7. Be concise and to the point.

Do not make an e-mail longer than it needs to be. Remember that reading an e-mail is harder than reading printed communications and a long e-mail can be very discouraging to read.

8. Use proper spelling, grammar, and punctuation.

As in all forms of written communication, this is not only important because improper spelling, grammar, and punctuation give a bad impression of your company, but also essential for conveying the message properly. For example, using *u*, *r*, and *ur* for *you*, *are*, and *your* is inappropriate for formal messages—mails with no full stops or commas are difficult to read and can sometimes even change the meaning of the text—and if your program has a spell checking option, why not use it?

9. Do not write in CAPITALS.

IF YOU WRITE IN CAPITALS IT SEEMS AS IF YOU ARE SHOUTING. This can be highly annoying and might trigger an unwanted response in the form of a flame mail. Therefore, try not to send any e-mail text in capitals.

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10. Avoid long sentences.

Try to keep your sentences to a maximum of 15–20 words. E-mail is meant to be a quick medium and requires a kind of writing different from letters.

11. Use active instead of passive voice.

Try to use the active voice of a verb wherever possible. For instance, 'We will process your order today' sounds better than 'Your order will be processed today'. The first sounds more personal, whereas the latter, especially when used frequently, sounds unnecessarily formal.

12. Keep your language gender-neutral.

It is important to be gender-sensitive. Avoid using discriminatory language such as: 'The user should add a signature by configuring his e-mail program'. Apart from using he/she, you can also use the neutral gender: 'The user should add a signature by configuring the email program'.

13. Maintain coherence.

When you reply to an e-mail, you must include the original mail in your reply, Click 'Reply', instead of 'New Mail'. Some people say that you must remove the previous message since this has already been sent and is therefore unnecessary. However, if you receive many e-mails, you obviously cannot remember each individual e-mail. This means that a 'threadless e-mail' will not provide enough information and you will have to spend a frustratingly long time to find out the context of the e-mail in order to deal with it. Leaving the thread might take a fraction longer in download time, but it will save the recipient much more time and frustration in looking for the related e-mails in their inbox!

14. Do not overuse the high priority option.

We all know the story of the boy who cried wolf. If you overuse the high priority option, it will lose its function when you really need it. Moreover, even if a message has high priority, it will come across as slightly aggressive if you flag it as 'high priority'.

15. Do not attach unnecessary files.

By sending large attachments, you can annoy readers and even bring down their e-mail system. Wherever possible, try to compress attachments and only send attachments when they are productive. Moreover, you need to have a good virus scanner in place since your readers will not be very happy if you send them documents full of viruses!

16. Read the e-mail before you send it.

A lot of people do not bother to read an e-mail before they send it out, as can be seen from the many spelling and grammar mistakes contained in e-mails. Apart from this, reading your e-mail through the eyes of the recipient will help you send a more effective message and avoid misunderstandings and inappropriate comments.

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17. Take care with abbreviations and emoticons.

In business e-mails, try not to use abbreviations such as BTW (by the way) and LOL (laugh out loud). The recipient might not be aware of the meanings of the abbreviations, and in business e-mails these are generally not appropriate. The same goes for emoticons, such as the smiley :-). If you are not sure whether your recipient knows what it means, it is better not to use it.

18. Be careful with formatting.

Remember that when you use formatting in your e-mails, the sender might not be able to view formatting, or might see different fonts than you had intended. When using colours, use a colour that is easy to read on the background.

19. Take care with rich text and HTML messages.

Be aware that when you send an e-mail in rich text or HTML format, the sender might only be able to receive plain text e-mails. If this is the case, the recipient will receive your message as a .txt attachment. Most e-mail clients, however, including Microsoft Outlook, are able to receive HTML and rich text messages.

20. Do not use e-mail to discuss confidential messages.

Sending an e-mail is like sending a postcard. If you do not want your e-mail to be displayed on a bulletin board, do not send it. Moreover, never make any libellous or discriminating comments in e-mails, even if they are meant to be jokes.

21. Avoid using URGENT and IMPORTANT.

Even more so than the high-priority option, you must at all times try to avoid these types of words in an e-mail or subject line. Only use this if it is a really, really urgent or important message.

22. Use the Bcc: field or do a mail merge.

When sending an e-mail, some people place all the e-mail addresses in the *To:* field. There are two drawbacks to this practice: (1) the recipient knows that you have sent the same message to a large number of recipients, and (2) you are publicizing someone else's e-mail address without their permission. One way to get round this is to place all addresses in the *Bcc:* field. However, the recipient will only see the address from the *To:* field in their e-mail, so if this was empty, the *To:* field will be blank and this might look like spamming. You could include the mailing list e-mail address in the *To:* field, or even better, if you have Microsoft Outlook and Word, you can do a mail merge and create one message for each recipient. A mail merge also allows you to use fields in the message so that you can for instance address each recipient personally. For more information on how to do a Word *mail merge*, consult the *Help* in Word.

23. Use Cc: field sparingly.

Try not to use the *Cc:* field unless the recipient in the *Cc:* field knows why they are receiving a copy of the message. Using the *Cc:* field can be confusing since the

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recipients might not know who is supposed to act on the message. Also, when responding to a *Cc:* message, should you include the other recipient in the *cc:* field as well? This will depend on the situation. In general, do not include the person in the *Cc:* field unless you have a particular reason for wanting this person to see your response. Again, make sure that this person will know why they are receiving a copy.

24. Do not reply to spam.

By replying to spam or by unsubscribing, you are confirming that your e-mail address is 'live'. Confirming this will only generate even more spam. Therefore, just hit the delete button or use e-mail software to remove spam automatically.

Sample E-mail Messages

Though you may be familiar with sending and receiving e-mail messages, we have provided some sample e-mail messages in the pages that follow. You can initially see the e-mail template (Figure 13.1) followed by some sample mails in Exhibits 13.21–13.26.

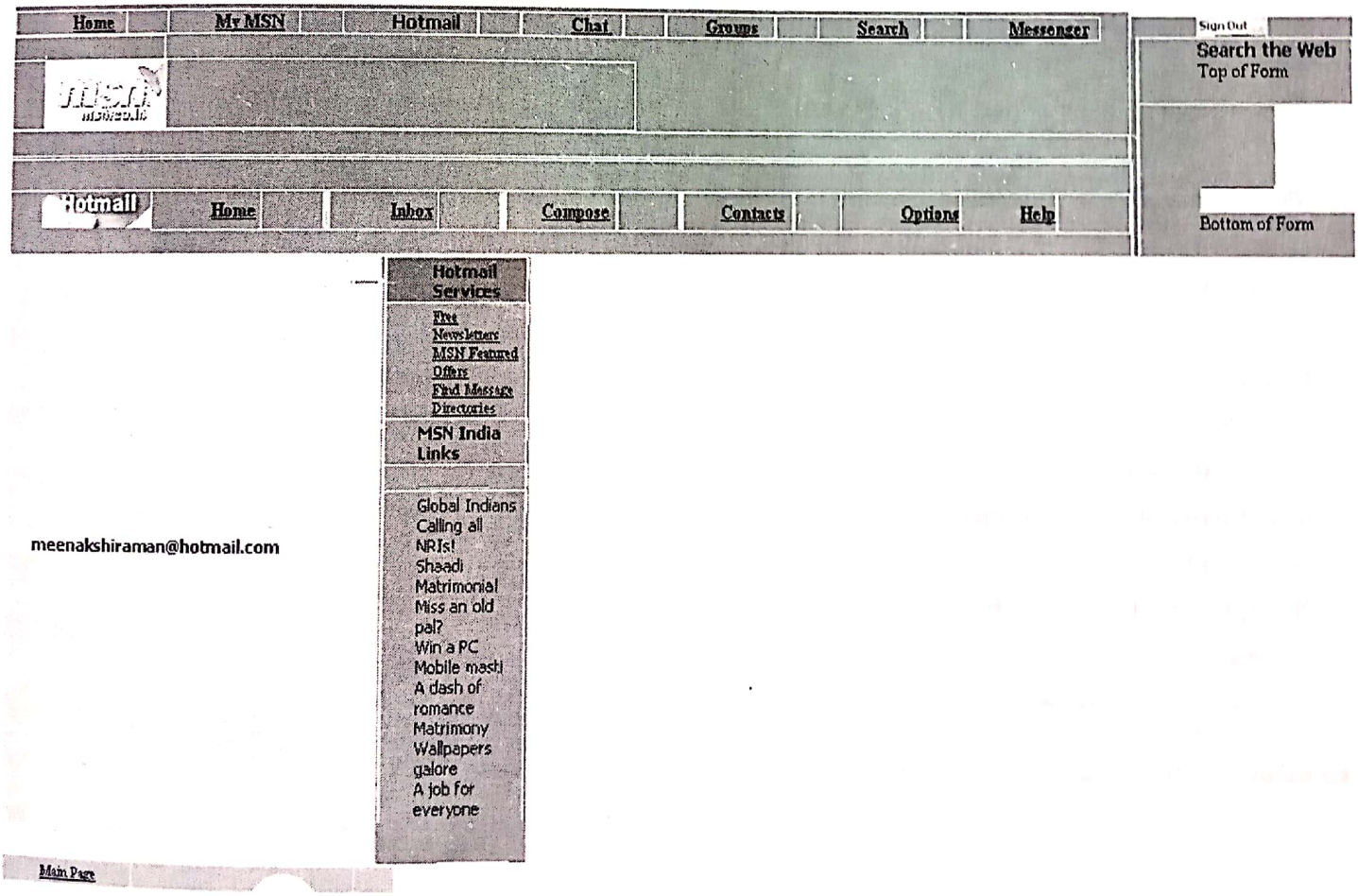

Figure 13.1: E-MAIL TEMPLATE

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From : "Dean, Academic" <xyz@hotmail.com>

To : "study abroad group" <sag@bu.edu.in>

CC : "Dean, Educational Development" <abc@bu.edu.in>

Subject : **Students preparing to study abroad in II sem 02–03**

Date : Thu, 11 Jul 2002 16:02:36–0400

Dear students

We hope you enjoy your time abroad next semester—it will be one of the most important and rewarding times of your education to date. To help you get the most out of it, we encourage you to read online reviews of past international students' experiences at our partner universities. They provide relevant advice and unbiased information from students in the know. You can also contact these past international students if you have further questions.

This resource is provided by iAgora.com, and you can find it online here: http://istudy.iagora.com

We wish you a wonderful experience abroad!

Dean, Academic

From
Prof. XYZ
Dean, Academic
Best Institute of Technology
New Delhi
Ph: Off: 91 11 2345678
Res: 91 11 789012
Fax: 91 11 7654321

Exhibit 13.21: SAMPLE E-MAIL 1

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Dear Friends and Family of XYZ,

August 10th is just around the corner, and we're sure you are looking forward to celebrating XYZ's wedding day!

As a service of Angel Art And Design, we'd like to let you know that, for your convenience, you can browse XYZ's wedding registry and purchase a gift of modern home furnishings and/or contemporary, original art online at http:///www.angelartanddesign.com. To view the registry, just click on the following link: http://www.angelartanddesign.com/registrysamplewedding.html

Wish best wishes for the happy couple,

Sincerely,

Angel Art And Design

p.s. A client of Angel requested that we send you this e-mail message. We will not e-mail you again unless you request to be added to the Angel Art And Design mailing list. Simply reply to this message with 'Add' as the subject header. Thank you!

Exhibit 13.22: SAMPLE E-MAIL 2

Subject: **Confirmation of membership**

Dear Mr ABC

Thank you very much for showing interest in joining our association and also sending the membership fee. Your membership details are given below:

Name: ABC

Membership Number: 234

Fee Paid: Rs 1000

Validity: Till 31 July 2004

You will be receiving your weekly newsletters, annual magazine, and other information. Please visit www.iais.org the official website of our association to know about the range of activities of the association.

Thank you once again for being a part of us.

Yours sincerely

XXX

Exhibit 13.23: SAMPLE E-MAIL 3

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14 Reports

Introduction
Objectives
Characteristics of a Report
Types of Reports
Importance of Reports
Formats
Prewriting
Structure of Reports
Writing the Report
- First Draft
- Visual Aids

Revising, Editing, and Proofreading
Samples

INTRODUCTION

A nurse at the hospital reports to the doctor in the inpatient ward about the condition of each patient. A foreman, at the end of the day, reports to the manager the progress of the work carried out in his supervision. The manager of a bank sends a periodic report to the Head Office on the state of deposits, advances, overdraft limits, etc. during the period. Another manager posted in a remote rural area reports to the Head Office about the difficulties faced in sanctioning loans to farmers. A publishing firm keen on introducing a new series of paperbacks into the market has to ask for a report on the current reader preference. The Managing Director of a bank would like to get a report on the efficacy of the measures introduced by him to promote efficiency in the branch offices.

Reports are a part of our lives—starting from school reports through news reports on TV and Radio to many kinds of reports we are required to submit in the course of our work.

From time to time, the Government sets up committees and commissions to report on various issues of social, political, and economic importance. There are various Parliamentary committees such as Committee on Human Resources, Committee on Agriculture, Committee on Industry, Committee on Science & Technology, Committee on Environment & Forests, and so on are set up to discuss, analyse, and report on various matters pertaining to the respective Ministries.

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The word 'report' is derived from the Latin 'reportare'—'to bring back'. Over a period of time, it has evolved to mean that the gathered information is unbiased and evidence-based.

Such committees meet from time to time, work out a detailed plan to conduct surveys and collect data from various sources, and finally submit their findings and recommendations in the form of a technical report.

But what is a report? A report is a major form of technical/business/professional communication. In writing a report, a person who possesses certain facts, ideas, or suggestions useful for courses of action transmits this information to another person who wants to use it.

A report can be the description of an event by a person who witnessed it to somebody else who was not actually present on the scene. It can be the description of the conditions that did exist, that do exist, or that are likely to exist. In short, we can say that a report is usually a piece of factual writing, based on evidence, containing organized information on a particular topic and/or analysis of that particular topic. It is formal in nature and is written for a specific purpose and audience. It discusses the topic in depth and contains conclusions and recommendations if required.

A report is usually a piece of factual writing, based on evidence, containing organized information on a particular topic.

OBJECTIVES

The purposes for which reports are written vary widely. Given below are some important purposes of reports:

- To present a record of accomplished work (Project report)
- To record an experiment (primary research report/laboratory report)
- To record research findings or technical specifications (a report on the details of a new product)
- To document schedules, timetables, and milestones (a report on a long-term plan)
- To document current status (an inspection report)
- To record and clarify complex information for future reference (a report on policies and procedures)
- To present information to a large number of people (annual report)
- To present organized information on a particular topic (a report describing the working of various divisions of an organization)
- To recommend actions that can be considered in solving certain problems. (recommendatory report)

CHARACTERISTICS OF A REPORT

1. Precision: Effective reports clearly reflect their purpose. While putting together a report, your *investigation, analysis,* and *recommendations should be directed by this central purpose.* Precision gives unity and coherence to your report and makes it a valuable document.

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Define Your Purpose

The purpose of your message determines everything in it—the format, content, sequence, and words you use. Spend some time first thinking about what you want to achieve and how you want your readers to respond.

In writing business reports, your purpose can be to inform, persuade, motivate, or express feelings—or a combination of these.

2. Factual Details: Your report should be very detailed and factual. The point of your report is to go into details, the kind of details your specific audience needs. The scientific accuracy of facts is very essential to a good report. Since reports invariably lead to decision-making, *inaccurate facts may lead to disastrous decisions.*

Irrelevant facts make a report confusing; exclusion of relevant facts renders it incomplete and is likely to mislead.

3. Relevance: The facts presented in a report should be not only accurate but also relevant. While it is essential that every fact included in a report has a bearing on the central purpose, it is equally essential to see that no relevant information is excluded. *Irrelevant facts make a report confusing; exclusion of relevant facts renders it incomplete and is likely to mislead.*

4. Reader-orientation: A good report is always reader-oriented. While drafting a report, *it is necessary to keep in mind the person(s) who is (are) going to read it.* A report meant for the layman will be different from one meant for technical experts.

5. Objectivity of recommendations: If recommendations are made at the end of a report, they must be impartial and objective. They should come as a logical conclusion to investigation and analysis. They must not reveal any self-interest on the part of the writer.

6. Simple and unambiguous language: A good report is written in simple, unambiguous language. It is a document of practical utility; hence it should be free from various forms of poetic embellishment such as figures of speech. It should be clear, brief, and grammatically accurate.

- **Clarity:** A good report is absolutely clear. Clarity depends on proper arrangement of facts. Report writers must proceed systematically. They should make their purpose clear, define their sources, state their findings, and finally make necessary recommendations. They should divide their report into short paragraphs with headings, and insert other suitable signposts to achieve greater clarity.
- **Brevity:** A report should be brief. It is difficult to define brevity in absolute terms. Nor can brevity be laid down as a rule. All that can be said is that a good report is as brief as possible. Brevity should not be achieved at the cost of clarity. Nor should it be at the cost of completeness. Sometimes the problem being investigated is of such importance that it calls for a detailed discussion of facts. Then this discussion should not be evaded. Brevity in a report is the kind of brevity one recommends for a précis. *Include everything significant and yet be brief.*
- **Grammatical accuracy:** The grammatical accuracy of language of a good report is of fundamental importance. It is one of the basic requisites of a good

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A good report is:
- precise and brief
- factual
- unambiguous and accurate
- relevant
- reader-oriented
- objective and homogeneous
- detailed and documented

report as of any other piece of composition. Remember that *faulty construction of sentences makes the meaning obscure and ambiguous.*

7. Special format: The technical report uses a rather involved format including cover, title page, table of contents, list of illustrations, letter of transmittal, and appendices. These have to be prepared according to a set standard, which will be presented later in this chapter.

8. Illustrations: Most technical reports contain illustrations, which may be tables, graphs, maps, drawings, charts, or photographs.

9. Homogeneity: Your report should deal with one topic at a time. All the sections of your report should focus on that topic.

10. Documentation: Technical reports acquire more value when adequately documented by acknowledging sources of information in an appropriate style.

TYPES OF REPORTS

On the basis of purpose, frequency, or mode of reporting, reports can be classified as follows:

- Informative, Analytical (Purpose)
- Periodic, Special (Frequency)
- Oral, Written (Mode of presentation)

Informative Reports

Informative reports focus on documenting new information; analytical reports assess information in order to propose course of action.

An informative report, as the name suggests, entails provision of all details and facts pertaining to the problem. For instance, it could be a report that attempts to trace the growth of Company X in the automobile industry. In a report of this kind, the presentation of all details that led to the growth of Company X should be listed in a chronological order.

Structural Organization

As the presentation of information is the basic purpose of the report, details are worked out in a systematic and coherent manner. The structural orientation and its significance in an informational report should be clearly evident to the reader.

In a report of this kind, the various sections are simple and self-explanatory. The introduction is followed by a presentation of information or facts and a conclusion thereafter, where all the details are collated in brief as a recap of earlier sections. Recommendations do not arise in this type of report.

The main purpose of an informational report is to present the information in an objective, factual, and organized manner. It presents the situation simply as it is. To write an informational report, all you need is to collect data, arrange it in an appropriate order and present it in a style appropriate to technical writing.

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Analytical Reports

An analytical report is also known as interpretative or investigative report. If a report merely presents facts pertinent to an issue or a situation, it is informative. On the other hand, if it analyses the facts, draws conclusions, and makes recommendations, it is described as analytical report. For instance, a report which presents production figures for a particular period is informative. But if it goes into the causes of lower production in that period, it becomes analytical, interpretative, or investigative.

The analytical report comprises stages in which there is a proper identification of the problem, analysis, and subsequent interpretation. Recommendations or suggestions are then incorporated in the report, depending upon what is required by the report writer. Thus, in a problem-solving method, the steps observed are as follows:

- Drafting problem statement
- Evolving criteria
- Suggesting alternatives and evaluation
- Drawing conclusion(s) and making recommendations

Many reports that you write in the course of your career cannot always be classified neatly as informative or analytical. As a writer, the challenge will be to design a report best suited to the assignment at hand.

Patterns

The structure of an analytical report may follow any of two patterns—inductive or deductive (Table 14.1).

Inductive Methodology An inductive ordering follows a simple, logical arrangement in which you proceed from the sensible singular to the universal or simply from the known to the unknown. There are two premises or syllogisms that conjoin to yield a final conclusion, e.g.,

Syllogism 1	This fire warms
Syllogism 2	And this fire warms
Syllogism 3	And this fire warms
Syllogism n	Also this fire warms
Conclusion	Therefore every fire warms

One could formulate umpteen number of syllogisms to reach a final conclusion which is always based on the number of experiments conducted or factors observed. Certain disciplines, in which experiments are carried out and surveys are conducted, naturally follow this pattern. Here, the progression is always in the nature of working on the known elements to arrive at an unknown conclusion.

However, inductive patterning, while normally followed for organization-based studies and experiments, suffers from a major drawback. As it is not based on any universal truth, it holds valid only up to the point where there is discovery of an

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Table 14.1: Inductive and Deductive Methods of Opening a Report

Inductive approach	Deductive approach
The automobile sector in India seems to have made tremendous headway in the last ten years. Company X has produced three models of cars. However, with the entry of new players in the market the company is facing stiff competition. There is also a slump in the market with excessive production and insufficient demand. The current study analyses the growth prospects of Company X vis-à-vis its competitors. The study focusses attention on the following three questions: 1. Who are the competitors? 2. Will Company X be able to face stiff competition from other companies? 3. What are the prospects of growth? The report attempts to analyse . . .	The automobile sector in India seems to have made tremendous headway in the last ten years. Company X has produced three models of cars. However, with the entry of new players in the market, Company X is facing stiff competition. There is also a slump in the market with excessive production and insufficient demand. The current study analyses the growth prospects of Company X vis-à-vis its competitors. It can easily be concluded that: 1. Company X is facing severe competition from companies Y and Z. 2. Unless and until Company X brings down its price to match that of the competitors, it will not be able to corner a substantial market share. It is recommended that an additional feature such as power steering be introduced as an extra facility or a reasonable reduction in price be carried out. Further, it is recommended that Company X target students pursuing professional courses, with a lowered price and basic strip down model, so that it appeals to their taste and fits their budget. The conclusions arrived at and recommendations made are based on the following study. Five sample automobile companies were taken . . .

issue that proves contrary to the findings in the report. It is by nature only relevant in the present and no universal claims to the same can be made.

Deductive Methodology On the other hand, a deductive ordering proceeds from the unknown to the known. Universal truths are taken as the formulation point for the problem. The various alternatives are suggested, evaluated, and conclusions drawn, keeping in mind the original problem stated. To understand the manner of approach in deductive methodology, let us take an example.

Conclusion Every fire warms
Syllogism 1 This fire warms
Syllogism 2 And this fire warms
Syllogism 3 And this fire warms
Syllogism n Also this fire warms

Structural Organization

While in an inductive method the pattern of the report would normally follow the sequence of introduction, text, and terminal section, in the deductive method,

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the structure could be slightly different. It could begin by stating conclusions and recommendations which are then followed by an introduction and the text section. This pattern would be observed if the report is of extreme importance and the receiver does not have the time to browse through the entire report. Merely a glance at the initial pages would enable the reader to assess the contents. Such readership would only be concerned with the conclusions and recommendations/ suggestions or plan of action.

Periodic and Special Reports

Periodic or routine reports are either informational or analytical in their purpose. As they are prepared and presented at regular, prescribed intervals in the usual routine of business they are called periodic or routine reports. They may be submitted annually, semi-annually, quarterly, monthly, fortnightly, weekly, or even daily.

Generally such reports contain a mere statement of facts in detail, in summarized form, or in the layout of a prescribed form, without an opinion or recommendation. Progress reports of various kinds, inspection reports, annual reports, and sales reports all come under this category.

At times the routine reports can be analytical or interpretative. For example, when the heads of various divisions in an organization submit annual assessment reports of their employees to the higher authorities, they assess the data and give their recommendations so as to enable their superiors to take certain decisions.

Special reports are related to a single occasion or situation. A report on the feasibility of opening a new branch, on the unrest among staff in a particular branch, or the causes behind the recent fire incidents in a factory are special reports. Special reports deal with non-recurrent problems.

Oral and Written Reports

Reports can be oral or written depending upon the mode of presentation. When you rejoin duty after attending an international seminar, you meet your officer and report about the deliberations of the seminar. This type of reporting comes under oral reporting.

An oral report is simple and easy to present. It may communicate an impression or an observation. While oral reports are useful, written reports are always preferred as they enjoy several advantages over the oral ones. Table 14.2 shows the varying advantages and disadvantages of oral and written reports.

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Table 14.2: ORAL AND WRITTEN REPORTS

Oral Reports	Written Reports
• Immediate feedback is possible	• Immediate feedback is not possible
• Do not add to the permanent records of the organization as the information/facts can be denied	• Contribute to the permanent records of the organization
• Audience needs to comprehend quickly as and when these are presented	• Audience can ponder over these reports and understand at their own pace
• May be encumbered with irrelevant facts and overlook important ones	• Are more accurate and precise as the writer will be careful in putting down the facts in writing.
• Cannot be referred to again and again	• Can be edited, reviewed, stored, and retrieved
• Have less professional value	• Have more professional value

THE IMPORTANCE OF REPORTS

A report is a basic management tool used in decision making. Hence it is extremely important for organizations of all types. Reports are vital, especially for large-scale organizations that are engaged in multifarious activities handled by different departments. Their top executives cannot keep a personal watch over all these activities. So they have to base their decisions on the reports they get from the heads of various departments. For large organizations, reports are indispensable. Reports bear a lot of significance both to the organizations in which they arise and to the organizations they are submitted to. The following list will give you an idea of how important reports and report writing are to the organizations and the individuals.

- *A report is the only tangible product of a professional.*

All the efforts of engineers, academicians, and researchers culminate in reports which convey to others the efficiency with which they carried out their assignments.

Remember that all reports carry legal responsibility. They can be used as legal instruments. Your activities, as an employee, and your competence at work are reflected through reports.

- *Reports enable decision making and problem solving in organizations.*

Based on the information presented, analysis discussed, or the suggestions rendered, administrators can make important decisions and solve problems of serious concern.

- *Reports help the authorities in planning new ventures and in evaluating men and material.*

If an organization wants to open a new branch in a nearby locality, it can plan for the same more effectively after going through the feasibility report prepared for this purpose. Similarly if the organization wants to assess the qualities and capabilities of a person, it can do so by going through the annual assessment form submitted by that person. It can also evaluate a newly introduced machine or product by listening to or reading the report prepared for this purpose.

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- *Reports are an important means of information dissemination within and outside the organization.*

Many of the routine reports such as inspection reports, inventory reports, or annual reports transmit information across and outside the organization.

- *Reports serve as a measure of the growth, progress, or success of an organization.*

The progress of any organization depends on the quality and quantity of information flown through its personnel in the form of oral or written reports. For instance, an organization focussing on research can bring out reports from time to time to provide information on the progress being made.

- *Reports serve as a valuable repository of information.*

Organizations of various kinds preserve reports of importance and value for a long time so that they can refer to these reports whenever needed. For example, an academic institution can refer to the previous assessment reports it had received from some committee in order to improve its performance.

- *Reports reveal gaps in thinking.*

When a report is read and comprehended, the recipient comes to know whether the report writer had thought and proceeded logically and whether he/she had conducted an in-depth study of the topic. If there is some lacuna in logical reasoning or thinking on the part of the writer, reports are sure to reveal them.

- *Reports develop certain skills in the writer.*

Reports not only help organizations but also help the writer to develop certain skills, such as the ability to organize, to evaluate, and to communicate with greater accuracy.

FORMATS

Your report may have any one of the following formats:

- Manuscript
- Letter
- Memo
- Preprinted form

Manuscript format: This is the most commonly used format for reports and is generally used for reports that are formal. The length of such reports can range from a few pages to several hundred. Further, manuscript form can be used for all types of reports—informational, analytical, or routine. As the length increases, these reports include more elements such as abstract, summary, appendix, glossary, and so on.

Memo format: A report you send to somebody within your organization will be in a memo format. Your analysis, conclusions, and recommendations are included

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PREWRITING

'anning for a report as important as e process of iting itself.

Before actually beginning to draft a report, you need to undertake various tasks, which may be referred to as the *preliminary steps to writing a report.* The effectiveness with which you carry out the tasks involved in these steps decides the effectiveness of your technical report. In fact, the planning stage is the most crucial one. Spend as much time as possible in collecting material, synchronizing details, and ensuring that nothing has been left out. If the planning is done in a detailed manner, there are very few chances of errors creeping in at the final stage. In fact, *planning for a report is as important as the process of writing itself.* The various steps involved in report planning are as follows:

- Understanding the purpose and scope
- Analysing the audience
- Investigating the sources of information
- Organizing the material
- Making an outline

Purpose and Scope

Purpose: The objective of your study
Scope : Extent of coverage

Assume that you, as the senior engineer of an organization, have been asked by your department head to study why the recently constructed flyover did not receive the anticipated feedback from the users. You are also required to suggest some measures to modify the same. Unless you are clear with the objectives of your task that your report involves, for example, (i) identifying the causes of dissatisfaction and (ii) suggesting remedial measures, you will not be able to proceed in the right direction. It is the *purpose* of the report that enables you to decide the amount or method of data to be collected , the quality and quantity of the information to be included in the report, and also the methodology to be adopted in analysing the situation and arriving at a solution.

Further, it is essential to understand the nature of the report—whether it is informative or analytical. In an informative report, you may stress factors contributing to collation of information at the time of stating the purpose. However, in an analytical report the writer would need to prepare a problem statement, the analysis of which becomes the thrust area of the report. Depending on the type of report to be written, there is bound to be a difference in the definition of the problem and purpose.

In most of the reports required by government organizations, the objectives are clearly stated as *terms of reference*. These terms are specific instructions given to

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the report writer as to what objectives are to be achieved through the report. For the sample given below:

You are directed

1. *to identify the causes behind the recent fire incidents*
2. *to analyse the existing fire fighting facilities*
3. *to suggest some preventive measures to stop the recurrence of such incidents*

Whenever the terms of reference are clearly specified you need to include them as they are, while stating the purpose of undertaking the task which your report involves.

Audience

'Adapt' your writing to meet the needs, interests, and background of the readers who will be reading your writing.

The audience for a technical report—or any piece of writing for that matter—is the intended or potential reader. For most technical writers, this is the most important consideration in planning, writing, and reviewing a document. You 'adapt' your writing to meet the needs, interests, and background of the readers who will be reading your writing. Lack of audience analysis and adaptation is one of the major causes of most of the problems you find in professional, technical documents—particularly while writing instructions, where inadequacies surface most glaringly.

One of the first things to do when you analyse an audience is to identify its type (or types—it is rarely just one type). In general, the audience can be categorized into three types as discussed below:

Experts are the people who know the theory and the product inside and out. They designed it, they tested it, they know everything about it. Often, they have advanced degrees and operate in academic settings, or in research and development areas of the government and business worlds. The non-specialist reader is least likely to understand what these people are saying—but also has the least reason to try. More often, the communication challenge faced by the expert is communicating to the technician and the executive.

Executives are the people who make business, economic, administrative, legal, governmental, and political decisions on the matter that the experts and technicians work with. If it is a new product, they decide whether to produce and market it. If it is a new power technology, they decide whether the city should implement it. Executives may sometimes have as little technical knowledge about the subject as non-specialists.

Non-specialists have the least technical knowledge of all. Their interest may be as practical as technicians', but in a different way. They want to use the new product to accomplish their tasks; they want to understand the new power technology enough to know whether to vote for or against it in the upcoming union election. Or, they may just be curious about a specific technical matter and want to learn about it—but for no specific, practical reason.

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It is important to analyse the audience in terms of characteristics such as the following.

Background—Knowledge, Experience, and Training

One of your most important concerns is just how much knowledge, experience, or training you can expect in your readers. If you expect some of your readers to lack certain background, do you automatically supply it in your document? For example, imagine you are writing a guide to using a software product that runs under Microsoft Windows. How much can you expect your readers to know about Windows? If some are likely to know little about Windows, should you provide that information? If you say no, then you run the risk of customers getting frustrated with your product. If you say yes to adding background information on Windows, you increase your work effort and add to the page count of the document (and thus to the cost). Obviously, there is no easy answer to this question—part of the answer may involve just how small a segment of the audience needs that background information.

Needs and Interests

To plan your document, you need to know what your audience is going to expect from that document. Imagine how readers will want to use your document; what will they demand from it. For example, imagine you are writing a manual on how to use a new microwave oven—what are your readers going to expect to find in it? Imagine you are under contract to write a background report on global warming for a national real estate association—what do they want to read about, and, equally important, what do they *not* want to read about?

Other Demographic Characteristics

There are many characteristics about your readers that *might* have an influence on how you should design and write your document—for example, age groups, type of residence, area of residence, sex, political preferences, and so on.

Audience analysis can get complicated by at least two other factors: mixed audience types for one document, wide variability within an audience, and unknown audiences.

More than One Audience You are likely to find that your report is for more than one audience. For example, it may be seen by technical people (experts and technicians) and administrative people (executives). What can you do? You can either write all the sections so that all the audiences of your document can understand them. Or you can write each section strictly for the audience that would be interested in it, then use headings and section introductions to alert your audience about where to go and what to stay out of in your report.

ou write to the vest common nominator of der, you're likely end up with a nbersome, ious book-like g that will turn off majority of ders. But if you 't write to that est level, you lose segment of your ders. What to do?

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Wide Variability in an Audience You may realize that, although you have audience that fits into only one category, there is a wide variability in its background. This is a tough one—if you write to the lowest common denominator readers, you are likely to end up with a cumbersome, tedious book-like thing that will turn off the majority of readers. But if you do not write to that lowest level you lose that segment of your readers. What to do? Most writers go for the majority of readers and sacrifice the minority that needs more help. Others put the supplementary information in appendices or insert cross-references to beginners' books.

Use the following guidelines to make your report comprehensible to the non-specialist reader:

- Add information readers need to be able to understand your document.
- Omit information your readers do not need.
- Add examples to help readers understand.
- Change the level of your examples.
- Change the organization of your information.
- Use more or different graphics.
- Add cross-references to important information.

Investigating the Sources of Information

To accomplish the objectives of your report, you require facts and ideas. You may find them in company records, reports, bulletins, pamphlets, and periodicals; you may use library sources to look for information; you may observe some incident and collect the facts or ideas; you may conduct personal interviews with people to get information; you may circulate questionnaires to get data for your report.

Investigating the sources of information is a kind of spadework. It is to be done right in the beginning. The extent of investigation will, of course, depend on the length and importance of the report. The important means of collecting data for your report are:

- searching library material, internal records, or databases
- personal observation
- conducting personal interviews or telephone interviews
- preparing and circulating questionnaires

Library Search

In reports on subjects of a general nature, library research may be found useful. This includes reference to standard reference books and past as well as current issues of newspapers, trade publications, research journals, and magazines.

Examples: Report on the analysis of online marketing strategies
Report on recent trends in software industry

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Nowadays, many online library catalogues may assist you in identifying the appropriate books, journals, or periodicals quickly and easily.

When reading to secure information for your report, you may find the following suggestions helpful:

- Visualize the facts. Connect words to the facts to which they refer.
- Understand the dictionary meanings and connotations of the words.
- Examine factual statements and figures for their accuracy and logic.
- Distinguish between vague and definite statements, between hasty generalizations and careful judgements, between opinion and fact.
- Scan the material for important points found in topic sentences.

To evaluate and finalize your sources, ask yourself the following questions:

- Does the source have a reputation for honesty and reliability?
- Is the source potentially biased?
- What is the purpose of the material?
- Is the author credible?
- Where did the source get its information?
- Can you verify the material independently?
- Is the material current?
- Is the material complete?
- Do the claims of the source stand up to scrutiny?

Internal Records Most of the relevant information is already contained in the old files of the institution. Sometimes there are precedents, and old findings and recommendations may be of considerable help. So it is very important to go through the old files of the organization. Declining sales or rising cost of production are recurring phenomena. And their causes are also usually similar. In these cases, old files may provide some valuable information.

Examples: Report on the history and growth of XYZ Institute

Report on the admission pattern adopted by ABC University

Database Search You can collect data for your report by surfing various databases, the addresses of which are obtained through Internet search. But if you are not effective and efficient in your searching, you may end up with information overload or wastage of time. The following guidelines will enable you to carry out a quick and purposeful database search:

- Choose appropriate databases: You may want a good technical/business/academic database. However, journals on your topic may be in a database that also includes journals on other subjects.
- Use multiple search engines: Do not limit yourself to a single search engine, especially if you are looking for less popular topics. Try your research on several

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engines by using *metacrawlers,* special engines that search several search engines at once.

- Use keywords and phrases: For instance, if you want to write a report on 'Importance of artificial intelligence in decision making', you would select the keywords or phrases such as artificial intelligence, decision making, management, and corporations. Use synonyms or word equivalents whenever possible, and use quotation marks around phrases to look for the entire phrase instead of separate words.
- Use appropriate order: Search engines look for the words exactly as you key them in. If the words occur, but not in the same order, you may miss relevant hints.
- Avoid stopwords: Stopwords are those words the computer disregards and will not search for. Common ones are: a, an, the, of, by, with, for, and to.
- Use variations of your terms: Use abbreviations (MD, CEO) , synonyms (primary, major), related terms (group, team, collaboration), different spellings (fiber, fibre), singular and plural forms (analysis, analyses), and nouns and adjectives (environment, environmental).
- Use appropriate search operators: Narrow or broaden your search by including AND, OR, AND NOT, WITHIN, NEAR, or ADJ. They can help you create complex, precise search strategies. (Examples: poverty AND crime AND gender; radiation NOT nuclear; endangered ADJ species; phylogeny NEAR ontogeny; orchids AND growing OR planning.)
- Refine your search if necessary: If you end up with more than 60 or 100 links to sort through, refine your search. If your first page of results does not have something of interest, you have entered inadequate or too few words. Also, pay attention to whether you are searching in the title, subject, or document of the database. Each will fetch you different results.

Personal Observation

Observation is *seeing with a purpose.* Personal observation is used as a method of data collection for securing first-hand information for your reports. It is based on your sensory perception and memory and often combined with other methods of data collection.

While observing personally, you not only observe but also form a mental impression of what you had perceived. In other words, your observation appeals to your senses. For example when you conduct an experiment in a laboratory, you use this method to collect data for your lab report.

Examples: All laboratory reports

Report on fire incidents

The two kinds of observation are (i) controlled observation and (ii) uncontrolled observation. The former is generally used in scientific research where scientific

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carry on an experiment and record findings. Scientists, for example, may conduct a particular experiment under specific conditions of temperature and pressure. They set the stage and then observe. On the other hand, in uncontrolled observation, the observer views things as they are. For instance, you would resort to uncontrolled observation when you collect data for writing a report on the working conditions prevalent in a particular factory.

Given below are some tips for successful personal observation:

- Be focussed on what to observe.
- Be objective and unbiased in your observation.
- Do not rely entirely on your memory.
- Carry paper and a pen to make notes.
- Note down all observations on the spot.
- Make a clear distinction between what you have seen and what you have felt.
- Check the accuracy of facts.

Interviews

An interview is an *interaction or conversation with a purpose*. It is an effective method for collecting primary information directly from an expert. It allows for a direct exchange of information, and the interviewee's voice, facial expression, gestures, and general behaviour all contribute to this exchange of information. The answers you receive are influenced by the types of questions you ask, by the way you ask them, and by your subject's cultural and language background.

Interviews conducted with the purpose of collecting data for a report are called data collection interviews. They can be either face-to-face/in-person or telephonic. In general, data collection interviews are conducted for the following specific purposes:

- to gather facts or subjective data such as attitudes, preferences, opinions, tastes, or emotional reactions
- to determine facts known to a single individual or group of people
- to substantiate the data collected through other sources

A successful interview requires careful planning and organization to ensure that you get the information you really need.

Preparing Questions By going prepared with a set of questions, you will feel confident and you will not waste your or the respondent's time. You will also create a better impression on the respondent if you are well prepared. There are four basic types of interview questions:

- *Open-ended questions* invite the interviewee to offer an opinion, not just a yes, no, or other one word answer, help you learn the reasons behind a decision rather than just the facts, and diminish your control of the interview.

  Example: What do you think are the major reasons for the employees' unrest?

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Guidelines for planning and conducting a face-to-face interview and also for preparing questions for the same.

Planning

- Get an appointment.
- Be clear about your purpose.
- Carry pen, note pad, and recording accessories.
- Get prior permission for recording.
- Be ready with a strategy to bring the respondents to focus, if they deviate.
- Prepare a list of questions. (open end)
- Visualize opening and last question.
- Dress appropriately.
- Reach on time.

Conducting the interviews

- Briefly explain the purpose.
- Exhibit active listening.
- Be accurate in recording.
- Don't enter into an argument.
- Assume a subordinate position.
- Avoid too many interruptions.
- Be tactful.
- Be flexible.
- Don't get unnerved.
- Finish in time.
- Assure confidentiality.
- Avoid embarrassing questions.
- Thank the respondent.
- Keep the lines of communication open.

- *Direct open-ended questions* give the interviewee some freedom but give you more control.

  Example: What is your role in bringing back normalcy among the employees?
- *Close-ended questions* require yes/no, short answers, produce specific information, save time, require less effort from the interviewee, and eliminate bias and prejudice in answers. They limit the respondent initiative and are not very useful for extracting information.

  Example: Do you feel the unrest among the employees will continue for a week?
- *Restatement questions* mirror a respondent's previous answer and invite the respondent to expand on that answer.

  Example: You said that the union leader would be meeting the employees this evening. Is that information correct?

While preparing the personal interview sheet containing the list of questions to be posed during the interview, remember the following guidelines.

- Prepare about twenty questions if your interview time is 30 minutes.
- Prepare questions with adequate focus on the topic.
- Think about sequence.
- Ask intelligent, smart questions.
- Use a mix of question types.
- Edit your questions.

The face-to-face data collection interview has both advantages and limitations.

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Advantages:

- Provides qualitative data as you can seek further clarification, if necessary, on any answers
- Enables you to observe the reactions of the respondent
- Can be effective and efficient if you go ready with a set of questions

Limitations:

- It is expensive and time-consuming if you have to meet people located at various places.
- You cannot contact a large number of people and hence the data may not be representative.
- As the answers are detailed and not in tabular form, you may find the analysis difficult.

Telephone Interview Sometimes interviews are conducted over the telephone. Such interviews are useful for opinion polls, when a limited number of questions are to be asked, and are usually more expensive than the personal interview. The telephone interview permits wide coverage of either particular or general groups, and uses a representative or random sample. The following lists summarize the merits and limitations of telephone interviews:

Merits:

- The telephone interview is the quickest of the survey techniques.
- The refusal rate is usually low among people who are reached by phone.
- The cost per completed interview is low for the sample covered.
- For studies of middle- and high-income groups the telephone interview may be satisfactory because most of the interviewees will have phones.
- Interviews may be scattered over a wide area within a city without adding to the cost.
- As compared with a mail questionnaire, the telephone survey is preferable because it usually costs less per return. Returns are higher on first solicitation, and they can be more effectively controlled from the point of neighbourhood distribution.

Limitations:

- Detailed data cannot be gathered by this method because the informants soon become annoyed or impatient. If the schedule is too lengthy, the informant may either hang up or give unreliable answers.
- As it is not possible to observe the body language of the informant, you may not be able to modify your strategies during the interview.
- It is difficult to secure privacy on party lines.
- Misinformation is hard to detect and check in short inquiries.
- If the lines are disturbed you may not be able to hear properly and record your answers accurately.

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Questionnaires

One of the best methods of collecting primary information is to ask people with relevant experience and opinions (known as survey). When prepared and conducted properly, surveys can tell you what a cross-section of people think about a given topic. A survey is reliable if it produces identical results when repeated. A survey is valid if it measures what it is intended to measure. Surveys are generally conducted for the following purposes:

- to collect data from a large number of people scattered over a wide geographical area
- to secure information on behaviour characteristics
- to gather opinions on attitudes
- to obtain facts

One of the most crucial elements of a survey is the questionnaire. To develop questionnaires, begin by making a list of points you need to determine. Then break these points into specific questions, choosing an appropriate type of question for each point. The following guidelines will help you produce results that are both valid and reliable.

- Ask only those questions relevant to your study.
- Provide clear instructions on how to fill out the questionnaire.
- Keep the questionnaire short and easy to answer.
- Formulate questions that provide easily tabulated or analysed answers.
- Avoid leading questions.
- Ask only one thing at a time (avoid double-barrelled questions).
- Pre-test the questionnaire.

The discussion that follows takes you through certain important aspects of questionnaire preparation. It tells you about the types of questions you may include, how to prepare them, how to sequence them, and also the types of sampling available.

Question Types *Open-ended* questions elicit descriptive answers. To enable the respondent to write his answer, provide adequate space.

Example: What is your opinion on establishing a gymnasium in our campus?

Close-ended questions require a definite answer such as yes/no, adequate/inadequate, satisfactory/unsatisfactory, sufficient/insufficient, etc. as framed in the question.

Example: What do you feel about the availability of space for establishing a gymnasium in our campus? adequate/inadequate

Multiple Choice type questions require the respondents to choose an option from the given choices.

Example: Which of the following time slots do you feel would be appropriate for the new gymnasium? (choose any two)

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(a) 5.30 a.m to 6.30 a.m.
(b) 6.00 a.m. to 7.00 a.m
(c) 5.00 p.m. to 6.00 p.m.
(d) 6.30 p.m. to 7.30 p.m.

Ranking type questions require the respondents to rank the items given from 1 to 5.

Example: Rank the following timings in the order of your preferences, from 1 (most preferred) to 5 (least preferred):

(a) 5.30 to 6.30 a.m.
(b) 6.00 to 7.00 a.m.
(c) 7.00 to 8.00 a.m.
(d) 5.00 to 6.00 p.m.
(e) 6.30 to 7.30 p.m

Short answer type questions require answers of few words or phrases. The answers are shorter than those for the open-ended questions.

Example: How often would you like to use the gymnasium per week?

Preparing Questions Whatever may be the type of questions you frame, remember to follow these guidelines:

- *Provide clear instructions.*

Explain how to fill out the questionnaire: whether to check the box, write something, rank, etc.

- *Keep the questionnaire short and easy to answer.*

Ask only such questions that are specific to your report topic; limit short answer questions.

- *Formulate questions that provide easily tabulated and analysed answers.*

Respondents will find it easy to mention numbers and facts than to summarize their opinions.

- *Avoid leading questions.*

If you ask 'Do you feel that hydrochloric acid is good for clogged drains?', it is a leading question as you give the readers a clue. They may answer 'yes' even without applying their mind. Instead, if you ask 'Which acid, in your opinion, is good for clogged drains?' and give options, they are forced to choose one of the options.

- *Ask about only one aspect at a time.*

Do you feel this experiment can be done under low pressure and high temperature conditions?—this is a double-barrelled question. You have to separate the issues of pressure and temperature and ask two questions.

- *Pretest the questionnaire.*

You can get better results if you select a group of ten people and ask them to fill out the questionnaire before you send it to your actual respondents.

If you are mailing rather than administering it in person, include a return postage-paid envelope along with a persuasive cover letter that explains why

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you are conducting the survey. It should convince your readers that responding is important

You will get a maximum of 10–20% response even in the best circumstances.

Sequencing To enable a continuous flow of thought, questions should be sequenced appropriately. You can follow either a logical or a psychological order. A logical sequence gives full consideration to the subject matter of questions, which must be covered thoroughly, and the chain of thought moves continuously from one question to the next. The psychological order, on the other hand, gives full consideration to the psychology of the respondent. The first few questions may be easy and then the reader may proceed to more difficult ones. To sustain the readers' interest, some transitions are used between questions. Personal questions are buried in the middle of the questionnaire. Similarly, questions that may reflect the respondent's intelligence and those that are likely to be of little interest to him also find a place in the middle.

Sampling When you want to contact a large number of people, you cannot mail the questionnaires to everybody.

It is enough if you choose a part of the group for sampling on the assumption that a representative number of responses indicates the whole. There are two major aspects to be considered in planning:

- Type
- Size

Types of Sampling Depending on the method of selection, sampling may be categorized as *random, stratified,* or *proportionate.* For instance, if you go for an employee survey, you can get the payroll list containing names of all employees and can select individual names at equally spaced intervals, such as every fifth or tenth name. That would be random sampling. For the same survey, if you divide the employees into categories and select names from each group, that will fall under stratified sampling. The last method, namely proportionate sampling, is used only when a specific class will affect the responses or conclusions. Here, you control the selection in such a way that characteristics of the whole group are represented proportionately.

Size The purpose of the survey determines the size of the sample—whether it is large or small. But an adequate sample is one that is large enough for generalization about certain characteristics.

The normal percentage of returns on most mail questionnaires is from 10 to 15 per cent. With a carefully selected mailing list and a questionnaire of general interest, returns often will reach 75 per cent or more. When they reach approximately 80 per cent, the findings are reliable without further testing because answers from those not responding would have little effect on the total responses.

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Covering Letter Generally all mail questionnaires are accompanied by a covering letter (Exhibit 14.1) which should be short and tactful. Its contents are:

- Purpose of the study
- Brief description of the questionnaire
- General instructions pertaining to the questions
- Request to fill in and return the form
- Assurance of confidentiality and follow-up

Sources for Mailing List

- Telephone directories
- List of voters
- List of customers
- Schools and Colleges
- Professional directories
- Censuses
- Automobile registration.

Advantages and Disadvantages Like other means of data collection, questionnaire also has its own advantages and disadvantages.

Advantages

- Less expensive than the other methods.
- Specific segments of population can be reached.
- More reliable than interviews because people generally take care in filling out written information.
- Questions can be answered at the convenience of the respondent.
- All respondents will receive the same questionnaire and hence the bias of the interviewer is eliminated.
- The respondent need not be identified.
- The respondent has a chance to deliberate and look up information.
- Analysis is easier.

Disadvantages

- There may be difficulty in securing replies.
- The data obtained may not be representative if you do not get reply from a large number of people.
- Often questions may be inadequately answered or unanswered.
- It is difficult to get complex or confidential information through a questionnaire.

Exhibits 14.1 and 14.2 show a sample covering letter and a sample questionnaire, respectively.

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October 10, 2003

Ravi Kumar
Best Institute of Technology
Agra

Dear friend

Sub: Data for survey on smoking

I am conducting a survey on smoking habits prevalent among the students of Best Institute of Technology. This survey is a part of my project work under the guidance of Prof. Jackson.

I would like to collect data that can be worked out into a report. As a student member of the project team I have offered to assist in collecting information from my friends. In this connection, I have prepared a questionnaire containing twenty-one questions pertaining to the smoking habits of students.

You will be helping my project team, and me, if you answer the questions that appear on the enclosed questionnaire. I have also enclosed a stamped, addressed envelope for your convenience in answering, and a courtesy copy of the questionnaire that you may keep.

Your answers are important to me in analysing the subject of the project we have taken up. Answering the questions will take but a few minutes of your time and will be of real value to me in completing this survey.

I assure you that the information you provide through your answers will be kept confidential and will be used for research purposes only.

Please send the filled out questionnaire before October 30, 2003.

I appreciate the time and effort you are sparing for me and I thank you for the same.

Yours sincerely,

(Ravi Kumar)

Encl: One questionnaire

Exhibit 14.1: SAMPLE COVERING LETTER

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QUESTIONNAIRE

Age: Sex: M/F

1. Do you smoke?
   ☐ Yes ☐ No
2. If your answer to Q1 is Yes,
   You started smoking when you were _____ years.
3. How many cigarettes do you smoke per day?
   ☐ Only occasionally (Not everyday)
   ☐ Less than 5 per day
   ☐ Between 5 and 10 per day
   ☐ More than 10 per day
   ☐ Not applicable.
4. Do you know that the major cause of lung cancer is smoking?
   ☐ Strongly agree
   ☐ Agree
   ☐ Not agree
   ☐ Strongly disagree
   ☐ Not sure
5. Even though I smoke, and I am aware that smoking and lung cancer are related, I personally feel that 'it is not going to happen to me'.
   ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not Applicable
6. Does anyone in your family smoke?
   ☐ Father ☐ Mother ☐ Brother ☐ Sister ☐ Others ☐ No one
7. Do you think that people pay attention to the Statutory Warning on cigarette packs that 'Cigarette smoking is injurious to health'?
   ☐ Yes ☐ No
8. If you smoke, which of the following apply to you?
   ☐ I have already quit smoking successfully.
   ☐ I tried to quit but was unsuccessful.

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- ☐ I will quit sometime later.
- ☐ I will continue to smoke as I enjoy it.
- ☐ I will continue to smoke, as I don't worry about the ill effects of smoking.

9. Do you feel smoking has serious effects on non-smokers?
   - ☐ Yes
   - ☐ No

10. If you are not a smoker, it is because
    - ☐ Your parents will never like it.
    - ☐ You never felt any need to experiment with smoking.
    - ☐ You strongly believe that smoking is dangerous to one's own health.
    - ☐ Other, specify _____ .

11. Do you think nicotine in cigarettes is addictive?
    - ☐ Yes
    - ☐ No

12. Do you strongly feel that girls should not smoke?
    - ☐ Yes
    - ☐ No

13. 'Passive Smoking' is related to respiratory problems among non-smokers. (Passive smokers are people who do not smoke themselves but inhale the smoke in the environment because of other smoker/s.)
    - ☐ Strongly agree
    - ☐ Agree
    - ☐ Disagree
    - ☐ Strongly disagree

14. According to you, 'My friend started smoking _____
    - ☐ To experiment.
    - ☐ Because friends smoke
    - ☐ To relieve himself/herself from anxieties
    - ☐ To look 'smart'.
    - ☐ Describe in your own words. _____

_____

_____

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15. Do you strongly feel that smoking affects men more?
☐ Yes ☐ No

16. I have heard of many people who smoked heavily but lived to a ripe old age, so smoking is not all that bad. Do you agree to this notion?
☐ Yes ☐ No

17. Do you strongly feel that smoking affects women more?
☐ Yes ☐ No

18. Do you strongly feel that men give up smoking easily when compared to women?
☐ Yes ☐ No

19. Do you strongly feel that women give up smoking easily when compared to men?
☐ Yes ☐ No

20. Do you feel that most lung cancer is caused by air pollution, automobile fumes, etc. ... not smoking?
☐ Yes ☐ No

21. With reference to smoking and public health, which of the following measures do you support:
☐ Smoking should be banned in public places.
☐ Cigarette advertisements in mass media should be banned.
☐ Sponsoring of sport events by cigarette manufacturers should be banned.
☐ Awareness campaigns on health hazards of smoking in colleges should be carried out.
☐ Others, specify ...

Exhibit 14.2: SAMPLE QUESTIONNAIRE ON ATTITUDES TOWARDS SMOKING

Web-based surveys (Internet surveys)

You must have come across several surveys/opinion polls conducted everyday by popular newspaper websites. Internet is a medium through which you can contact thousands and thousands of people simultaneously and conduct surveys. These surveys have several advantages as listed below:

- Most modern means of surveying
- Cheaper to conduct
- Reach a large number of people instantly, economically

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- Can improve survey response rates
- Can be made more attractive by using graphics and animation

Organizing the Material

Depending upon the topic, purpose, and audience, you can organize the material/data collected for your report in

- the order of occurrence;
- the order of importance; or
- a combination of orders.

Order of Occurrence

Order of occurrence is otherwise known as chronological order. Here, the data is presented in a sequence that depends on time that is more or less of uniform value—none of the parts are uniquely important.

Examples: History of a transaction
Procedure for manufacturing or installing equipment

In some cases, though time is still an element, it is not pertinent. Here sequence is more directional than temporal. The order is more that of movement than of occurrence, and movement may be in any direction.

Examples: A quarterly report on the volume of sales of a company having branches in Eastern, Western, Northern, Southern parts of India.
Report describing the plan of a building.

Order of Importance

When the matter/data collected for your report is not of uniform value, you may have to organize the information in descending or ascending order of importance. Generally, the descending order of importance is valid for informational reports as the reader is interested in looking for the most important information first.

Examples: Feasibility reports.
Here, immediate needs are more important than future needs.
Feedback report on the conference recently attended.

The ascending order of importance is used mainly to create dramatic suspense and reach the climax at the end of the report. This is inappropriate for most technical reports, as there is no need to create suspense. It is more effective in magazine articles and speeches as they slowly gain momentum. Of course, certain analytical reports based on a certain theory or principle may be organized in this order as the reader may wish to understand first the basic precepts or ideas on which the study is built.

Examples: Research reports
Developing a new system

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Combination of Orders

This order is particularly useful in reports involving a double assignment. A combination of order of occurrence and order of descending importance is fairly common.

Example: Report on the appraisal of a situation and the recommended changes.

Report on a problem and the suggested solution.

In short, examine the data as a whole, consider them for completeness, their relationship to the purpose of investigation, their total significance to the problem at hand and then organize in an appropriate order.

Making an Outline

It is extremely important to develop an outline of the report prior to commencing work on the report. The formatting of the report should be carried out only after completion of the outline.

An outline is a mechanical framework into which you can fit in bits and pieces of information you have collected for your report. It serves as a signpost to show you the right direction in which you need to proceed for writing your report.

Remember your school days when your teacher had asked you to write an essay. How did you begin? You thought about some points, organized them in your mind, and then jotted them down in some order. You revised them and modified the order. Then, keeping those points as guidance you started writing on each. Then you could produce a well-organized essay. Report writing also follows similar steps. Thoughts do not come to us in the way in which we want them to come. They come randomly and it is for us to organize them appropriately and systematically before we begin writing.

Preparing an outline requires a considerable amount of time. But the time you spend on a systematic outline is always beneficial to you as this helps you save time. On the other hand if you start writing your report without an outline your writing will lack organization and structure and end up in confusion. The outline indicates the main topics and sub-topics for your report in words or phrases. To prepare an effective outline, you may follow the tips given below:

- Use words or phrases.
- Use nouns whenever possible.
- Use parallel grammatical construction.
- Follow the principle of coordination and subordination.
- Use decimal numbering system.

Go through the following sample outline and the discussion thereafter to make your outline more effective.

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Sample Outline

Education System in India

1. Introduction
2. Status before Independence
3. Present Status
   - 3.1. School Education
     - 3.1.1. Primary
     - 3.1.2. Secondary
     - 3.1.3. Higher Secondary
   - 3.2. College Education
   - 3.3. University Education
4. Status of Women's Education
5. Merits and Demerits
6. Financial Support
7. Employment Prospects
8. Conclusions

Use Words or Phrases

The outline which you prepare with careful planning finally turns out to be the *Table of Contents*. Various parts of the outline are used as headings in the text of the report. Hence you should take care in choosing the words for constructing the headings of an outline. You can go for short construction (topic heading), frequently consisting of one or two words which merely identify the topic of discussion; you can also go for longer constructions (talking headings), frequently including prepositions that not only identify the subject matter covered but also summarize the material they cover. Given in Table 14.3 are examples of topic heading and talking heading as they may appear in a segment of an outline.

Table 14.3: Topic Headings and Talking Headings

Topic Heading	Talking Heading
4. Marketing Strategies 4.1. Feedback 4.2. Promotional Efforts 4.3. Distribution Network	4. Creating strategies for marketing 4.1. Collecting feedback from all areas 4.2. Designing strategies for promotional efforts 4.3. Setting up of new distribution network

Use Parallel Grammatical Constructions

Ideas that are parallel in thought must also be parallel in grammatical construction. Therefore, corresponding parts of an outline, being of equal significance, must be stated in the same grammatical form. In other words, equal-level headings should be parallel in structure so as to show similarity. Through parallel headings you can show such equal-level divisions consistently.

For example, if you use a noun phrase to express an idea under one subdivision, you must state the other parts of the same sub-division in noun phrases only.

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Similarly, if the heading for one division is a participle phrase, other points appearing under the same subdivision must be expressed in participle construction. Compare the following parallel and non-parallel constructions given in Table 14.4 to understand the effectiveness of parallel constructions in an outline.

Table 14.4: Parallel and Non-Parallel Constructions

Non-Parallel Construction	Parallel Construction
1. Advantages of computers 1.1. Internet Browsing 1.2. Promotes sales 1.3. Analysing Data 1.4. Managing Finance	1. Advantages of computers 1.1. Internet Browsing 1.2. Sales Promotion 1.3. Data Analysis 1.4. Financial Management
1. Introduction 2. Computers mark the beginning of a new era 3. What are the applications ? 4. Are they advantageous ?	1. Introduction 2. Computers: the beginning of a new era 3. Applications 4. Advantages

Avoid Needless Repetitions

Do not repeat words because repetition results in monotonous writing, which will make your outline dull and drab.

Look at the original and revised versions of a segment of an outline taken from a report on Education System in India given in Table 14.5.

Table 14.5: Avoiding Monotony in an Outline

Original	Revised
3. Present Status 3.1 School Education 3.1.1 Primary Education 3.1.2 Secondary Education 3.1.3 Higher Secondary Education	3. Present Status 3.1 School Education 3.1.1 Primary 3.1.2 Secondary 3.1.3 Higher Secondary

By simply eliminating the repetition of the word 'education' in all the subdivisions, we have avoided sounding monotonous.

Follow the Principles of Coordination and Subordination

Your outline indicates the level of each heading in the report, that is, how important each heading is. The closer a heading is to the margin, the greater is its importance in the report. Likewise, as the headings move away from the margin, they become less important.

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According to the principles of coordination, you should see to it that all the main headings are of the same level in terms of their relation to the subject of your report and also the seriousness of discussion. So it is important that when you organize your data, select appropriate main headings which are of equal importance to your report.

Table 14.6: COORDINATION OF HEADINGS

Illogical Coordination	Logical Coordination
2. Computers: Beginning of a New Era 3. Applications 4. Education 5. Industries 6. Advantages 7. Disadvantages	2. Computers: Beginning of a New Era 3. Applications 3.1 Education 3.2 Industries 4. Advantages and Limitations

As per the principles of subordination, the sub-headings should be appropriate to the main heading under which they are listed.

Consider the same excerpt given in Table 14.6 in Table 14.7. You can see what is meant by the principles of subordination:

Table 14.7: SUBORDINATION OF HEADINGS

Illogical Subordination	Logical Subordination
3. Applications 3.1 Education 3.2 Industries 3.3 Advantages 3.4 Limitations	3. Applications 3.1 Education 3.2 Industries 4. Advantages and Limitations

Follow a Suitable Numbering System

You may use either the conventional numbering system or the decimal numbering system to mark the levels of headings in outline.

The conventional system uses Roman numerals to show the main headings and the letters of the alphabet and Arabic numerals to show the sub-headings as shown below:

Conventional System
- I. First-level heading
  - A. Second level, first part
  - B. Second level, second part
    1. Third level, first part
    2. Third Level, second part
       a. Fourth level

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(1) Fifth level
(a) Sixth level
II First-level heading
A. Second level, first part
B. Second level, second part
....

The decimal system uses whole numbers to show the major sections. Whole numbers followed by decimal digits show subsections. That is, the digits to the right of the decimal show each successive step in the outline. The following is an example of this system:

Decimal System
1.0 First-level heading
1.1 Second level, first part
1.2 Second level, second part
1.2.1 Third level, first part
1.2.2 Third level, second part
1.2.2.1 Fourth level, first part
1.2.2.2 Fourth level, second part
2.0 First-level heading
2.1 Second level, first part
2.2 Second level, second part
....

Though you can use any of these numbering systems for your report, the decimal numbering system is more popular and more convenient to use. Of course, depending upon the existing practice in your organization, you can use any of these two systems. Whatever system you use, do remember that headings beyond the third level do not find a place in your Contents page. Of course, while making an outline that is prepared for your own purpose, you can go up to any level of headings.

STRUCTURE OF REPORTS

Just as several organs constitute our body, various elements combine together to structure a report. Knowing these elements will help you in writing better reports.

Though nineteen elements are listed after this discussion, you need not use all of them in your report. While some of them may be included in all reports, some may find a place only when your report gets published. However, you can select the elements of structure keeping in mind the following parameters:

- Usefulness
- Terms of reference
- Existing practice

Usefulness refers to the need for including any particular element. For example, when you write an informational report, you do not require a section on

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